hybrid stories is Rabindranath Tagore's irreverent parody of the form, simply titled 'Detective'. Anil Menon and Tanuj Solanki's meta-entries attempting to deconstruct the genre, or, rather, the soul of the detective, are interesting exercises.

The ones that fall apart are overcooked, blending too many disparate elements (fantasy, occult, time travel, horror) in too short a word limit. Sri Lankan writer Navin Weeraratne is unfortunately unable to do complete justice to his conceit in the ambitiously titled 'DeathGPT'.

The police detective stories are more robust and enjoyable than the ones with amateur detectives set in the present. Amateur detectives are perhaps a relic of the past, which is why the best of the lot are from yesteryear writers: Feluda and Byomkesh in particular. Tamilvanan's 'Tokyo Rose', featuring a globetrotting superdetective, is a mad romp drawing from Tamil masala movie traditions.

THE POLICE DETECTIVE stories are more robust than ones with amateur sleuths set in the present

Among the police stories, Rajarshi Das Bhowmik's 'Detective Kanaicharan and the Missing Ship' is unique in that the detection is near-academic, involving extensive poring over maps and government archives. Vikram Chandra's 'Kama', featuring his hit character Sartaj Singh, subtly comments on the politics of desire and fascism without drawing attention to the themes.

At least a couple of stories offer rich descriptions of settings and sociopolitics. Practising psychiatrist Anirudh Kala's 'No Thermometer for Insanity', set in a mental asylum, stands out for its haunting environment. Likewise, Shashi Warrier's vision of rural Tamil Nadu circa 1946 in 'Murder in the Monsoons' is a grim account of an India that was and still is behind the shadows.

Vaseem Khan's 'Ghosts of Partition' is a sensitive short story built around post-traumatic stress disorder. The other historical detective story that impresses is Nev March's 'Arsenic and the Shepherd'.

The collection is overburdened with at least 10 Bengali writers. Marathi, Tamil, Malayalam, Hindi and Urdu crime fiction is underrepresented. The collection would be better served with more translations from these languages. Perhaps Hachette will roll out volumes three and four, in which these gaps in the editor's attempt to represent subcontinental detective fiction will be filled. ■

–Devarsi Ghosh

BOOKS

The Mysterious City

Anuradha Kumar's The Kidnapping of Mark Twain *paints an intriguing portrait of Bombay around the time of the American writer's visit*



THE KIDNAPPING OF MARK TWAIN
A Bombay Mystery
by Anuradha Kumar
SPEAKING TIGER
₹499; 344 pages

Looking for a juicy period mystery that involves some famous foreigners and lots of local colour? Then *The Kidnapping of Mark Twain* by Anuradha Kumar might be one to consider.

Set in Bombay of 1896, the story brings you a well-crafted web of mystery that revolves around the visit of American writer Mark Twain. Fact and fiction come together in a tale that embellishes on Twain's actual travelogue from the time—*Following the Equator: A Journey Around the World*—which describes the people and places he encountered. Kumar deftly weaves the warp of class and caste issues, the social milieu and believable characters, into the weft of Twain's observations to create a tapestry of insight and intrigue. And, in this case at least, east may be east and west may be west, but the twain do come together in a burst of epic events.

Unfortunately, while Kumar has clearly researched the book extensively, she often gets caught in a vortex of her own making, allowing the information she's gathered to overshadow the story's progression.

That some of the geography is off can be forgiven as creative licence. But there's a lot of repetition that should have been edited out. The number of times that we're reminded of Twain's real name, for example, can be rather annoying. And while we're all for introspective protagonists, the depths that American Trade Consul Henry Baker plumbs seem a trifle unnecessary. His constant stream-of-consciousness sharing leads to an analysis paralysis, wherein not much action takes place for large swathes of the text.

Meanwhile, the Watson's Hotel (at Kala Ghoda in South Mumbai) in all its glory is at the crux of the story, forming a picturesque backdrop for conversations and investigations. Mentions of the erstwhile Byculla Club (although sadly, no mention of its famous soufflé!) and fabulous parties in palatial Malabar Hill residences are juxtaposed against the city's cotton mill ethos and the 'native' Indian reality.

In fact, 19th-century Mumbai, with its layered complexity, is the most fascinating character in the story. While the others flit in and out to our disinterest, the city is brought to life wonderfully well by Kumar. So, while the book may not quite work as a mystery, it merits a read for its intriguing portrayal of old Bombay. ■

–Priya Pathiyan